

CAPSTONE · TRANSPARENCY & ACCOUNTABILITY

Sahihi

Public participation notices you can trust — on WhatsApp, in plain language, and never invented.

Kenya · 47 counties · English & Kiswahili · github.com/Guantaijp/sahihi

The notices exist. Finding them is the problem.

Published as pictures

Nairobi County posts participation notices as photographs of printed letters. A deadline inside a JPEG cannot be searched, forwarded or read aloud.

Scattered by design

47 county assemblies, 47 executives, two houses of Parliament, the Gazette, newspapers and notice boards. No single place to look.

Stale or unverifiable

One county assembly site's latest post is from 2024. Elsewhere, dates and venues circulate on social media with no source anyone can check.

NAIROBI COUNTY'S OWN ASSESSMENT, AUGUST 2026

0.74%

of Nairobi residents take part in public engagement forums.
Most are simply never told.

Source: Nairobi City County Government statement on the draft civic education and public participation policy, 7 August 2026

Built for the phone people already have

A resident, not a researcher

Someone who wants to know what is being decided about their ward — and does not know a memorandum from a gazette notice.

WhatsApp, because that is where they are

No app to install, no account to create, no portal to navigate. Plain text works on a low-end phone and on a weak connection.

Their language

English and Kiswahili today; the wording sits in one file per language, so another language is a translation job, not a rebuild.

What they get

- What is open in my county
- What it is about, in plain words
- The deadline, and whether it is confirmed
- Where to go or where to send views
- The official source, to check for themselves
- A reminder before the deadline

One conversation, four steps

STEP 1

Say where you are

"Kisumu", or ask a question like "what is open about health?"

STEP 2

See what is open

A numbered list: county notices first, then national ones that apply everywhere.

STEP 3

Learn how to take part

Reply with a number for the venue, the time, how to submit, and the source link.

STEP 4

Be reminded in time

"remind 1" sends one message before the deadline. "stop" cancels it and deletes your data.

The rule: it would rather say nothing than guess

Most assistants fill gaps with plausible text. For civic information, a plausible wrong deadline is worse than silence — someone travels to a hearing that has already closed.

Situation	What Sahihi does
A detail is not in the official source	Shows "not yet confirmed — please check the official source below". Never fills it in.
Every single notice	Carries the issuing body, a link to the document, and the date a human last checked it.
A deadline passes	The notice disappears from every reply automatically, the same day.
Only a news report, no official source	It does not go in. A real example: a reported 28 September deadline is still shown as unconfirmed.
The AI rewording layer	Optional, off by default, and may only rephrase text that is already verified — never add a fact.

A real answer, from a real source

Every fact in this reply was checked against the Clerk of the National Assembly's notice of 16 September 2026, which lists public hearings on the Tobacco Control (Amendment) Bill in seven counties.

The user learns the venue, the date, the time, how to take part, and where the information came from — in one message, under 4,000 characters, on any phone.

Ask "remind 1" and one message arrives before the deadline.
Ask "stop" and the record is deleted.

WHATSAPP

Kisumu

Here's what's active in **Kisumu County** right now:

1. Tobacco Control (Amendment) Bill — public hearing in Kisumu Town

Deadline: 2026-09-26

Venue: Kisumu Social Hall, 9:00 AM to 1:00 PM

Source: National Assembly of Kenya —
parliament.go.ke

Last verified: 2026-09-19

2. The Public Participation Bill, 2025 — Senate comments

Deadline: **not yet confirmed — please check the official source below**

Working today, not a mock-up

31

verified notices on file,
every one traced to an
official document

47

counties recognised,
including misspellings and
"I live in Nairobi county"

59

automated tests, covering
the trust rules and the
data file itself

2

languages, switched by a
single word in the
conversation

Channel

WhatsApp webhook with Meta signature verification, plus a browser chat page that runs the same engine for demos.

Privacy

Reminders are opt-in, every confirmation says how to stop, and "stop" erases the person's record.

Stack

NestJS and TypeScript, a daily reminder job, and a JSON knowledge base that a non-developer can edit.

How it travels

One notice, 47 counties

A national tier already exists: a bill before Parliament is entered once and answers every county, including those with no local data yet.

The country is a data file

Place names, notices and wording are data, not code. Another country means a new place list and a new source list — the engine, trust rules and tests carry over.

Cheap to run, cheap to use

Text only, no images, no app. Works on a basic handset and a weak signal, and the AI layer is optional — it never gates a reply.

The bottleneck, named honestly

Collection, not software. 40 counties still have no local notices on file, because most are advertised in newspapers, on notice boards and at barazas.

The answer is a fetcher that reads the sources that are machine-readable — Parliament, county sites, the Gazette — and puts candidates in a queue a human approves before anything reaches a user.

Automation proposes. A person still verifies. That is what keeps the promise on the previous slide true.

How AI tools built this

The idea and the trust rules are ours. Claude Code did the building — and, just as usefully, the source-hunting that a prototype usually skips.

Built

Rewrote the prototype into a NestJS service, added the paging, search, national tier, reminder scheduler and the WhatsApp channel.

Hardened

Found and fixed four real bugs, added webhook signature checks, consent and deletion, and wrote 59 tests including ones that guard the data file.

Researched

Read Parliament's hearing schedule out of a PDF table and county notices out of scanned JPEGs, then entered only what the official document stated.

Refused

Left out a hearing series it could not verify officially, and marked a news-reported deadline as unconfirmed rather than publishing it.

The same discipline runs through the product: an AI may improve the wording of a verified notice, but it is never the source of a fact.

What happens next

Next	Why it matters
Fetcher with a review queue	Turns collection from an hour per county into minutes of approving candidates
Meta template approval	Required before reminders can legally reach people days later
Pilot with one county's civic groups	Local partners supply the notices that never appear online
Finish Kiswahili, then add a third language	Field labels are still English; the structure is already per-language
Privacy notice and retention rule	Phone numbers are personal data under Kenya's Data Protection Act

github.com/Guantaijp/sahihi

Run it locally in two commands; the browser chat page needs no WhatsApp account.

Sahihi — Kiswahili for correct, accurate, authentic.
The name is the specification.